At 6:00 p.m., one hour before the start of the president's television address, Dobrynin showed up in Rusk's office. "Rusk looked unusually serious," remembered the ambassador later. He handed him the text of the forthcoming presidential speech. It was accompanied by a personal letter to Khrushchev in which Kennedy stated that his desire was to avoid misunderstanding between the two governments. He also issued a warning to Khrushchev: "I must tell you that the United States is determined that this threat to the security of this hemisphere be removed." The letter ended with a call for a dialogue: "I hope that your Government will refrain from any action which would widen or deepen this already grave crisis and that we can agree to resume the path of peaceful negotiation."[13]

Rusk warned Dobrynin not to underestimate American will and determination—a key point of Kennedy's letter. Dobrynin knew nothing about the deployment of the missiles in Cuba, and for him the text of the president's statement came as a complete surprise. According to Rusk, Dobrynin's face went pale. "I saw him age ten years right in front of my eyes," recalled Rusk. Whatever he told Rusk in return, Dobrynin sent an encouraging report to Moscow. Rusk, wrote Dobrynin, "was clearly in a nervous and agitated mood, even though he tried to conceal it." Never having been informed by his government about the missiles, Dobrynin continued to deny their presence in Cuba. "Rusk," he wrote to Moscow, "was told that the actions of the USA government cannot be justified by the absolutely unconvincing motives which are not grounded in the factual situation … and that all responsibility for possible grave consequences of the aforementioned actions of the United States will be entirely on the American administration."[14]

In the Kremlin, Khrushchev and his colleagues received the text of Kennedy's speech not from Dobrynin but from the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, to which it had been delivered by an American diplomat one hour before the start of Kennedy's address, the same time Rusk handed a copy of the speech to Dobrynin. The news that Kennedy was about to declare a naval blockade instead of the feared invasion of Cuba was met with a sigh of relief, if not jubilation. "This is not a war against Cuba but some kind of ultimatum," declared Khrushchev. "We've saved Cuba!" He could live with a blockade. "Even earlier, when making a decision on sending missiles to